RAMBAM'S LAWS OF ETHICS - HILCHOT DEOT

# Rambam's Diet: Why Staying Healthy Is Halacha

Hilchot Deot Ch. 4

**Sefer:** Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Deot (Rambam's Laws of Ethics) **Chapter:** 4 (complete) **Shiur:** Part 5 of the seven-part series, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom and Facebook, Tuesday 24 November 2020 **Dedications:** Le'ilui nishmat Davida bat Chaim Alexander, Barbara Feldman's mother, and le'ilui nishmat Chana bat Kamil

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

---

## Recap

Last week (Chapter 3): a person must not cut himself off from the world or keep fasting. Eat well, live a regular life, and do it for the right motives. Eating, drinking and sleeping for the right purpose are all part of *avodat Hashem.*

This week, the Rambam explains *how* to live a healthy life: what to eat and drink, your schedule, when and how to sleep. "This is a very rare and intriguing chapter. We don't get this from other rabbis."

---

## Part 1: Introduction – Five Points Before We Begin

**הואיל והיות הגוף בריא ושלם מדרכי השם הוא, שהרי אי אפשר שיבין או ידע דבר מידיעת הבורא והוא חולה, לפיכך צריך להרחיק אדם עצמו מדברים המאבדין את הגוף ולהנהיג עצמו בדברים המברין והמחלימים**

Since keeping the body healthy and whole is among the ways of God, because one cannot understand or know anything of the Creator while ill, a person must distance himself from what destroys the body and accustom himself to what heals and strengthens it.

### 1. This is halacha, not advice

As the Rabbi said in the first shiur, the Rambam is *paskening* here. It is no different from how to wear tefillin or tzitzit. "You can't eat unhealthy food and say, 'I'm a good Jew, I'm just not being good to my body.'" Health isn't merely a physical necessity; it's an indispensable part of Torah. **According to the Rambam, it is *assur* to be unhealthy.** If a person is able to lose weight and keeps overeating, he is violating a prohibition like any other.

### 2. A guarantee

At the end of the chapter, the Rambam, "one of the greatest rabbis and one of the greatest doctors we've ever had," guarantees that whoever follows it will not fall ill.

### 3. Holistic and preventative

The Rambam doesn't tell you what to do *if* you have a particular illness. He gives a whole schedule, from waking to sleeping, to *prevent* illness. If you are already ill, he says, go to a doctor.

### 4. Why so much detail?

Why not simply say "look after your health and see your local doctor"? The Rabbi compared the end of **Hilchot Kiddush HaChodesh**, one of the hardest sections of the Mishneh Torah, with its chapters of astronomical calculation. There the Rambam explains that he set it all out so that people of understanding would lack nothing, and **would not need to go searching for it in other books.** The same applies here. Medical knowledge belongs in the book of halacha, all in one place.

### 5. Where does it come from, and does it still apply?

| Question | The Rabbi's answer |
|---|---|
| Is this from the Gemara or from medicine? | Mostly from **the medicine of his time.** Commentators try to source every line in the Talmud, but many statements have no source, and some contradict the Gemara. |
| How can the Rambam contradict the Gemara? | The Kesef Mishneh (Rabbi Yosef Karo) asks this about the laws of bloodletting. He answers that the Gemara spoke of a different climate, country and time. The Rambam is telling us what is correct *for his day.* |
| Is it a problem that he learned from non-Jews (his medical teacher was **Galen**)? | No. In Kiddush HaChodesh the Rambam says the astronomy came from Greek books, but since it is proven, **"we don't rely on the authority of the person who said it, but on the proofs."** Accept the truth from whoever says it. |
| What about statements that are medically wrong today? | That doesn't contradict the eternity of halacha. (a) The Rambam drew on the medicine of his time, and medicine develops. "Had the Rambam been around today, he would have crossed out and added to Chapter 4." (b) Halacha already rules that the Gemara's medical remedies **may not be relied on** today, whether because nature has changed or knowledge has. Relying on them and failing would bring the Sages into disrepute. |

"The vast majority of what he says is still true today, and it's remarkable that someone 800 years ago wrote this with such clarity."

---

## Part 2: Eating and Drinking

### Eat only when hungry

Never **לעולם לא יאכל אדם אלא כשהוא רעב ולא ישתה אלא כשהוא צמא, ואל ישהה נקביו אפילו רגע אחד** eat unless hungry, nor drink unless thirsty, and never hold back from relieving yourself, even for a moment.

- **We eat to live; we don't live to eat.** Don't eat because you're bored, anxious, depressed or have nothing else to do.
- **Drinking only when thirsty.** The Rabbi noted that, as far as he knows, today it is well established that you should drink even when not thirsty, to avoid dehydration. This is one place where medicine has moved on. Someone in the class made the same point, and he agreed.
- **Never delay going to the toilet.** Always err on the side of caution. The Rambam develops this later.

### Stop at three-quarters

Don't eat until your stomach is full; stop **לא יאכל אדם עד שתתמלא כריסו אלא יפחות כמו רביע משבעתו** about a quarter short of being satisfied.

It takes sensitivity to know when you've reached three-quarters, but the point is: never eat until completely full.

### Water with meals

Drink only a little water during the meal, diluted with wine if needed. Drink more once the food begins to digest. Today too, the Rabbi said, the advice is to drink before or after a meal rather than during it.

### Exercise before eating: the morning routine

The **כללו של דבר יגע גופו ויתיגע בכל בוקר עד שיתחיל גופו לחום, וישקוט מעט עד שתתיישב נפשו, ויאכל** rule: exert and tire the body every morning until it begins to warm, rest a little until you settle, and then eat.

"I'm not putting words in the Rambam's mouth. He tells you clearly." The ideal day:

1. Wake up early.
2. Exercise until your body is warm. This is what *"afflict your body"* means: the process hurts, but you're happy afterwards.
3. Have a hot shower.
4. Rest until your breath settles.
5. Then eat breakfast.

Don't sit down to a main meal straight after three hours of driving, because your body isn't warm enough to digest properly.

### How to eat

- **Sit in one place,** leaning slightly to the left. Don't eat while walking, or while riding (today, driving).
- **No exercise after eating.** "Those who have supper and then go for a swim: for the Rambam, a very bad idea." The Rabbi said his father always said the same. Exercise in the morning, never after supper, and not late at night on a treadmill when the body is tired. "Better not to exercise at all than to exercise after eating."

---

## Part 3: Sleep

Day and night are 24 hours; it **היום והלילה ארבע ועשרים שעות, דיו לאדם שישן שלישן שהוא שמנה שעות** is enough for a person to sleep a third of them, eight hours, ending shortly before sunrise.

- **"Enough."** The word **דיו** implies a maximum: you don't need *more* than eight hours.
- **The Ben Ish Chai** says between six and eight hours: not more than eight, like the Rambam, and not less than six, which is unhealthy.
- **Doesn't the Rambam also say to give the nights to Torah?** In Hilchot Talmud Torah 3:13 he writes that a person acquires most of his wisdom at night, and should not waste his nights on sleep, food or talk. There is no contradiction. That refers to the waking hours of the night that people usually waste. With only a candle it was harder to learn, so the night needed protecting.
- **A personal story.** At Gateshead Yeshiva, the young, enthusiastic Rabbi Kada planned to cut his sleep to learn more. The Rosh Yeshiva, Rabbi Gurwicz, told him: "You're not cleverer than the Rambam. The

Rambam told you eight hours. Sleep eight hours." Don't try to be clever by cutting sleep. It will catch up with you.

### How to lie

| Instruction | The Rambam's reason | Note |
|---|---|---|
| Not on your back or front, but on your side | — | The Gemara gives a reason of *tseniut* |
| Left side at the start of the night, right side at the end | Digestion: food is still being digested early in the night | Kabbalah says the same for a completely different reason: the start of the night is *din*, the end is *rachamim* |
| Don't go to sleep soon after eating | The food needs to digest | "People who eat far more than they need at a dinner and go to bed half an hour later are asking for trouble." |

---

## Part 4: What to Eat, and in What Order

- **Laxative foods before the meal:** grapes, figs, mulberries, pears, melons, cucumbers and the like. Eat them first, and the main meal a little later. "This is very true today."
- **Binding foods after the meal:** pomegranates, quinces, apples, a type of pear.
- **Light before heavy:** poultry before meat, eggs before poultry, small animals before large. Don't put pressure on the digestive system all at once.
- **Seasons:** in summer, cooling, lightly spiced food, with vinegar to prevent dehydration. In winter, warming food such as hot soup, and more spice ("apparently mustard is good").
- **Eat less in summer than in winter.** Summer intake should be about two-thirds of winter's, on top of stopping at three-quarters full.
- **Unripe fruit** should be avoided, and that is still true today. Honey and wine are bad for children and good for the elderly.

### Foods the Rambam warns against

| Category | Examples | The Rabbi's comment |
|---|---|---|
| **Very harmful – never eat** | Large, old, salted fish; old salted cheese; mushrooms; old salted meat; wine fresh from the press; any food with a bad smell | The Rambam dislikes old food. Salt was the preservative of the day. "I'd imagine he wouldn't like six-month-old freezer food either. Pot Noodles and processed food in a box for months would be poison for the Rambam, and we know today they are." |
| **Harmful – rarely** | Large fish, milk more than 24 hours old, lentils, refined white bread, cabbage, onion, garlic, mustard, radish | "White bread isn't good." |
| **Not great** | Water fowl, bread kneaded with oil, and so on | "I don't know how true all of this is today." |

---

## Part 5: The Great Principle – Loose Bowels

This is a great principle **ודבר זה כלל גדול ברפואה: כל זמן שהרעי נמנע או יוצא בקושי, חלאים רעים באים** in medicine: whenever the bowels are blocked or move with difficulty, serious illnesses come.

Always keep the bowels loose, and if anything, err towards that extreme. Regular constipation is a sign that illness is on its way.

**The remedy for constipation:**

- **Young people:** in the morning, salted vegetables or legumes with olive oil, or the broth of spinach or beets with oil and salt, **without bread**, which blocks you. Olive oil is a well-known laxative, even today.
- **Older people:** every morning, hot water with honey (essentially a tea), then **don't eat for about four hours.**

The Rabbi said he does something similar himself: only teas for a good few hours in the morning. "It definitely works for me."

**From the class:** Is breakfast forbidden? No. The four-hour morning fast is only for someone suffering from constipation, for a few days until things are loose again. What applies to everyone is not eating until after you've exercised and warmed up.

### The three principles

As long as a person exercises and exerts himself a great deal, does not eat to satiety, and his bowels are soft, **כל זמן שאדם מתעמל ויגע הרבה, ואינו שבע, ומעיו רכין, אין חולי בא עליו... ואפילו אוכל מאכלות רעים** no illness will come upon him… even if he eats bad foods.

| Do these three… | …and you'll be healthy even with bad food | Neglect them… | …and you'll suffer even with good food |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Exercise and exertion | | Sitting comfortably, no exercise | Pains and weakness |
| 2. Never eat to the full | | Overeating, even healthy food | "Like poison," the main cause of illness |
| 3. Loose bowels | | Regular constipation | Illness is coming |

Overeating is like poison to the body, **ואכילה גסה לגוף כל אדם כמו סם המות, והוא עיקר לכל החלאים** .and it is the root of all illness

*Whoever guards his mouth and tongue guards his soul* :(Mishlei 21:23) **שומר פיו ולשונו שומר מצרות נפשו** *from troubles.* Plainly this means not speaking lashon hara, which comes in a later chapter. The Rambam .reads it here as guarding your mouth from eating when you don't need to

---

## Part 6: Bathing, Bloodletting and Relations

### The weekly bathhouse

.A person should go to the bathhouse once every seven days **יכנס אדם למרחץ משבעה ימים לשבעה ימים**

The bathhouse wasn't jumping in the shower. It was a three- or four-hour affair. That is why the Gemara forbids going to the bathhouse before praying Mincha: you could easily miss the time.

- Don't go straight after eating, or when hungry.
- First perspire: exert yourself and sweat out "all the bad stuff." Then wash with **hot, then lukewarm, then cold** water. Don't stay too long.
- Relieve yourself before and after.
- **Dress fully before going outside, even in summer.** They had a room for this outside the bathhouse. "Especially now in the winter."
- Afterwards, rest. Don't go straight to work or exercise. A short sleep is great, and then eat. Don't drink water in the bathhouse.

"Basically this is today's sauna, followed by a cold shower. I don't know who's got the time for all of this, and with his schedule I don't know if the Rambam did either. Maybe once a week."

### Bloodletting and relations

- **Bloodletting**, very common medicine in those days, should not be done too often.
- **Relations:** the life force should be used sparingly. **אל תתן לנשים חילך** ("Don't give your strength to women," Mishlei 31:3). The Rambam cites doctors who held that one in a thousand dies of other illnesses and 999 of excessive relations. "This isn't true today, but it's interesting to see his perspective."

---

## Part 7: The Guarantee

**כל המנהיג עצמו בדרכים אלו שהורינו אני ערב לו שאינו בא לידי חולי כל ימיו עד שיזקין הרבה וימות, ואינו צריך לרופא** Whoever conducts himself in the ways we have taught, I guarantee that he will not fall ill all his days until he grows very old and dies, and he will not need a doctor.

- The Rambam is **not** one of those rabbis who guarantees success for saying something on a particular day at a particular time. Nowhere does he do that. This guarantee is different because for him it is **science**, at least for his time.
- **The exceptions he lists:** a body that was unhealthy from birth; someone who kept bad habits from childhood; or a plague or famine. "There'll be some sort of pandemic, then I can't guarantee anything," the Rabbi noted, speaking in November 2020.
- "If you wake up at 80 and want to take the Rambam up on his promise, that's a bit late. But the more we do this, the better."
- Everything here is for a **healthy** person. Someone already ill must see a doctor and follow their own programme.

### Never live without a doctor

A Torah scholar may not live in a town that lacks ten things. Among them are **a doctor**, a bathhouse, a toilet, a synagogue and a teacher of children. "This shows the importance of the medical profession: the NHS, the key workers."

---

## Summary: The Rambam's Three Main Principles

1. **Exercise.** Every morning if you can, 20 minutes to half an hour, then shower, relax and eat.
2. **Never eat until you're absolutely full.** Overeating is the root of most illness.
3. **Keep the bowels loose.**

Also: sleep six to eight hours, on your side; eat light foods before heavy ones; avoid old, preserved and processed food.

"Don't think you can be a religious Jew and not keep these things. This is an essential part of *avodat Hashem.* When we exercise, we can think that we're doing it for HaKadosh Baruch Hu, because you can't live a life of serving Him with aches across your body."

### From the class

**Flora:** The Rambam wrote a famous letter (to Rabbi Shmuel ibn Tibbon) saying he had no time to eat or sleep. Did he keep these rules? The Rabbi answered that this was towards the end of his life, when he was employed as physician to the court. Earlier he had a much more relaxed life and wrote most of his works then. "I'm sure he kept up his exercise, 100%. The main thing is not to overeat."

---

## Coming Up

- **Next Tuesday, 1 December, 8:00pm:** a conversation with **Rabbi Dr Joshua Berman**, "one of the leading biblical scholars of this generation." Not to be missed.
- **The following Tuesday:** a shiur on Chanukah.

- **The series then pauses** for Chanukah and the winter, and resumes early in the new year with Chapters 5–7.
- Recordings are on Facebook (no account needed). Shiur dedications are available; please contact the Rabbi.

---

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/EVdqd4ypHa8 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com